

From Access to Employment: A Strategic Policy Position on the Future of Access to Work

Executive Summary

The Government's Journeys to Access to Work report presents a timely opportunity to rethink how Access to Work is positioned within England's employment and skills system.

The report reinforces what employers, disabled people and employment providers have recognised for many years: Access to Work is one of the UK's most effective employment interventions, yet its impact is constrained by inconsistent awareness, lengthy processing times and limited integration with wider employment support.

At the same time, Government has made inclusive economic growth, reducing economic inactivity and increasing employment among disabled people central to its missions. These ambitions cannot be realised through national programmes operating in isolation. They require locally integrated systems that connect health, skills, employment, employers and communities.

Rather than viewing Access to Work simply as a grant scheme, it should be recognised as a strategic enabler of labour market participation. Devolution presents an opportunity to embed Access to Work within local employment ecosystems, ensuring disabled people receive coordinated support before employment breaks down rather than after crisis has occurred.

The Changing Landscape

Demand for Access to Work has grown significantly in recent years as more people remain in work with long-term health conditions, neurodiverse conditions and disabilities. This reflects positive societal change, greater openness around disability and increasing employer willingness to recruit diverse workforces.

However, demand has outpaced operational capacity. Long waiting times risk job offers being withdrawn, employment opportunities being lost and existing employees leaving work unnecessarily. For employers, uncertainty reduces confidence in recruiting disabled people. For individuals, delays can have profound impacts on income, wellbeing and career progression.

These challenges sit alongside wider reforms, including the Government's drive to tackle economic inactivity, expand supported employment, strengthen employer engagement and deepen devolution of employment and skills services. Collectively, they provide a compelling case for redesigning Access to Work as part of a more integrated system.

A Shift from Programme Delivery to System Leadership

The evidence suggests that improving Access to Work is not simply a matter of increasing administrative capacity. The greater opportunity lies in redesigning the wider customer journey.

Too many individuals discover Access to Work only after they have encountered significant barriers at work. Employers frequently lack awareness of the scheme, while employment advisers, careers professionals and health practitioners often have limited understanding of when referrals should be made.

This creates unnecessary friction across the system.

Instead, Access to Work should become a routine component of employment support, embedded within careers advice, supported employment, apprenticeships, local authority services, NHS pathways and employer engagement activity.

Success should be measured not only by the number of grants awarded, but by improved employment outcomes, reduced economic inactivity, higher job retention and increased employer confidence.

The Role of Mayoral Combined Authorities

Mayoral Combined Authorities are increasingly responsible for shaping local labour markets through devolved employment, skills and economic development functions.

This creates an opportunity to position Access to Work within local inclusive growth strategies.

Combined Authorities could act as system convenors by:

- Embedding Access to Work within locally commissioned employment and skills programmes
- Developing shared referral pathways across Jobcentre Plus, local authorities, Integrated Care Systems, education providers and voluntary organisations
- Equipping employment advisers with the knowledge to identify eligibility at an early stage
- Supporting employers to understand both their duties under equality legislation and the additional support available through Access to Work
- Using local labour market intelligence to target sectors experiencing workforce shortages where disabled people remain underrepresented

In doing so, Access to Work becomes part of a preventative employment strategy rather than a reactive intervention.

A More Collaborative Delivery Model

Future success will depend upon greater collaboration between central government and local partners.

National government should continue to provide strategic leadership, funding and policy direction, while local partnerships should be empowered to improve awareness, coordinate delivery and tailor support around local labour market conditions.

This collaborative approach reflects wider Government ambitions for public service reform, recognising that complex employment challenges are best addressed through place-based partnerships rather than isolated programmes.

Policy Recommendations

To maximise the impact of Access to Work, Government should consider the following priorities:

- Position Access to Work as a core element of the national employment strategy rather than a standalone disability programme.
- Integrate Access to Work within devolved employment and skills systems, enabling local partners to coordinate referrals and employer engagement.

- Invest in preventative support by ensuring disabled people are identified earlier through employment, education and health services.
- Simplify and digitise the customer journey while maintaining personalised support for those with complex needs.
- Improve employer engagement through targeted communications, practical guidance and stronger links with local business support services.
- Develop a shared outcomes framework measuring employment retention, progression, productivity and economic impact alongside processing performance.
- Strengthen co-design with disabled people, employers and delivery organisations so that future reforms reflect lived experience.

Conclusion

The Journeys to Access to Work report should be viewed not simply as an evaluation of a successful programme, but as a catalyst for wider system reform.

Improving Access to Work is not solely about processing applications more quickly. It is about creating an integrated employment system in which disabled people receive the right support at the right time, employers have the confidence to recruit inclusively, and local partners work together to remove barriers before they become crises.

For Mayoral Combined Authorities and local partnerships, this presents an opportunity to demonstrate how devolved leadership can deliver more responsive, inclusive and economically productive labour markets.

By embedding Access to Work within broader employment, skills and health strategies, Government can move beyond programme improvement towards genuine system transformation—supporting more disabled people into sustainable, rewarding employment while contributing to national economic growth and inclusive prosperity.